She revealed that she'd had squid for lunch at a restaurant.

British calamari! Mystery solved.

From the floor she said softly: *Please tell me you're not having to hold back my hair while I'm vomiting.*

Yes. I am.

I rubbed her back and eventually put her to bed. Weak, near tears, she said she'd imagined a very different end to Date Four.

Stop, I said. Taking care of each other? That's the point.

That's love, I thought, though I managed to keep the words inside.

13.

JUST BEFORE MEG RETURNED TO CANADA we went to Frogmore gardens for a walk.

It was on the way to the airport.

A favorite spot of mine, I said. It spoke to her as well. She especially loved the swans, and especially one that was very grumpy. (We named him Steve.) Most swans are grumpy, I said. Majestic, but sourpusses. I always wondered why, since every British swan was the property of Her Majesty, and any abuse of them, thereby, was a criminal offense.

We chatted about Euge and Jack, whom she loved. We talked about Meg's work. We talked about mine. But mostly we talked about this relationship, a subject so immense it seemed inexhaustible. We continued the talk as we got back into the car and drove to the airport, and kept talking in the car park, where I dropped her on the sly. We agreed that if we were serious about giving ourselves a chance, a real chance, we'd need a serious plan. Which meant, among other things, making a vow never to let more than two weeks pass without seeing each other.

We'd both had long-distance relationships, and they'd always been hard, and part of the reason had always been lack of serious planning. Effort. You had to fight the distance, defeat that distance. Meaning, travel. Lots and lots of travel.